MAKEUP ART

Stage Makeup: Straight, Character and Age

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The three jobs of stage makeup, the products that do them, and how to build a face that reads from the back of the hall without looking like a mask up close.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- corrective makeup
- character
- ageing
- greasepaint and cake
- hygiene

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Why stage makeup is not everyday makeup

Stage lighting washes out the face: a normal face under a bright fresnel loses most of its modelling, and the eyes disappear into shadow. Stage makeup restores what the light takes away - the shadow under the cheekbone, the line of the lip, the definition of the eye - and then exaggerates it for the distance.

The rule is distance, not quantity. A face made up for the fifth row will look like a mask in a photograph; a face made up for a camera will look blank from the fifth row. Design for the seat you are playing to.

Corrective, or straight makeup

Straight makeup makes a face look healthy and defined: a base matched to the skin, a crease shadow in the eye socket, a highlight above the cheekbone, a lip line slightly stronger than the natural one, and a setting powder. It is the base for everything else and it is what most actors need most nights.

Match the base to the neck, not the hand, and check it under the actual stage light. Foundation that looks right in a dressing-room mirror can be two shades too dark on stage.

Character makeup

Character work starts from the character's body, not from a photograph: what does this person eat, how do they sleep, what have they survived? Then choose two or three features to change and leave the rest alone. A nose, a brow and a jaw change reads as a different person; ten changes read as a mask.

Nose putty, crepe hair, spirit gum, wax and stipple are the standard tools. Learn them on your own face first, and never apply spirit gum to anyone with sensitive skin without a patch test.

Ageing

Age is not lines; it is gravity and loss of elasticity. Highlight the bones that emerge as fat pads shrink: the cheekbone, the jaw, the temple, the back of the hand. Shade the hollows under the eye and along the nasolabial fold. Grey the hair at the temples first, then the crown.

A young actor aged with lines alone looks like a young actor with lines. Add the body: a slower walk, a lower centre of gravity, a hand that grips the chair.

Kit, hygiene and the call

A basic kit: base, cream shadow, highlight, powder, brushes, sponges, cotton buds, micellar water, tissues, a small mirror and a headband. Share nothing that touches skin without cleaning it. Keep each actor's sponge labelled and replace it weekly.

Allow forty minutes for straight makeup and character work, ninety for ageing plus hair. Build the makeup into the call, not into the twenty minutes before the beginners' entrance.

Hair, wigs and the finished head

Makeup is half a head. Hair and wigs change a silhouette faster than any paint: a receding hairline, a braided crown, a wig with grey at the temples. Learn to block and pin a wig, to lace a front hairline, and to set a style that survives an hour of stage heat.

Match the wig to the period and to the actor's face. A wig that sits too low on the forehead makes every face look older and every character look tired. Pin the wig securely, tape the lace, and check it under the stage light from three metres.

Build a wig and hair plot alongside the costume plot: character, scene, wig or natural hair, who dresses it, and where it is kept between performances. Hair that is improvised every night is hair that eventually falls off on stage.

Exercises

1. Do a straight makeup on a partner under stage light and photograph it from three metres and from thirty centimetres.
2. Age yourself twenty years using highlight and shadow only, with no drawn lines.
3. Design a character face for a play you know, with a reference image, a materials list and a fifteen-minute application plan.

Where to read more

Richard Corson, Stage Makeup (any edition)

Herman Buchman, Stage Makeup (1949)

Rosemarie Swinfield, Stage Makeup Step-by-Step (1994)

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